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James Lincoln Collier

James Lincoln Collier was born on June 27, 1928. He is a member of Hamilton College's class of 1950 where he was a member of the Fallacious Five, a student run traditional jazz band. Mr. Collier is a noted writer of jazz and children's books and continues to play his trombone in the New York City area.

He was interviewed in New York City on January 14, 2007 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Manhattan filming for the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. I'm really pleased to have James Lincoln Collier with me today, author, trombonist and Hamilton class of 1950.

JLC: That's correct.

MR: Glad to have you here.

JLC: Yeah well I'm very happy to be here.

MR: I was reading some things about you and it sort of looks like you can trace your writing genes all the way back to the Plymouth Colony.

JLC: How did you find that out?

MR: There's a lot of stuff floating around.

JLC: Is there? Well it's interesting. Yeah, one of the hanging judges, Samuel Sewall of the Bay Colony was one of my ancestors and he's famous for being the hanging judge of course. But the important thing, one of the important things about him in addition to that was that he wrote the first anti-slavery tract produced in the United States. He wrote, his principle was I just do not see how God is differentiating between blacks and whites, they were all human and therefore slavery should not exist. That was his position on this, and that's been forgotten about him in all the calumny that's been heaped on him for the hanging judge business. But in the family we are very pleased about that because if he hadn't been a hanging judge Arthur Miller never would have been able to write *The Crucible*. So you see we're responsible for some great books. Just to follow that line of thought, we were responsible for some other rather important books. My great grandmother, through various family connections, knew the family of Henry David Thoreau. And in fact my great great grandmother boarded with the Thoreaus. And Thoreau fell in love with my great grandmother and wanted to marry her and there was a whole business about that and the family, my family, wouldn't hear of it because the Thoreaus really, they didn't have any money, they were kind of — couldn't quite get their stuff together. So they insisted that my great grandmother call the thing off and they sent her out to western New York State to let her cool down a little bit. And so that was broken up. And if the family

had not broken that up Thoreau would not have been able to build a cabin on a lake in Massachusetts, which of course produced the famous *Walden*. So that's the second great book that the family created by inadvertence. There's a third one actually. My grandmother's cousin, I believe that's the connection, Abigail May, married a lunatic, Bronson Alcott, who was responsible for creating a utopian colony called Fruitlands. And of course they scorned money and so nobody ever had any money and it was all a dreadful situation for everybody. And my family used to refer to her as poor cousin Abba because she married this very strange hippie basically was what he was. And so one of the daughters then, in order to save the family reputation, started writing books. And if it hadn't been for that situation we never would have had Louisa May Alcott writing *Little Women*. So that was the third book that the family has created by inadvertence. And there's actually a fourth one. My uncle, William Slater Brown, who liked to be known as Slater but was always known as Bill by the family and by most of the people that knew him, was a pacifist, had come to Columbia to study journalism, and in 1917, like a lot of young Americans, joined the Volunteer Ambulance Corps to go to France. He wouldn't fight of course, as a pacifist, but to belong to an ambulance corps and help the French soldiers was a great — it was an adventure. And World War I, for that generation, was the adventure. These guys didn't want to be left out, and so they would join the ambulance corps to go over there. So that's what he did. And he was on a ship and they were just coming out of the New York harbor here and it was a little chilly, it was getting evening, and my uncle went down back to his cabin to get a jacket. And he came up and a friend of his, Red Lemon, who he joined up with, was sitting and talking with a young man who had come along and asked for a cigarette, a light for his cigarette. And so my uncle was introduced, this is Bill Brown, this is Estlin Cummings. And they became great pals, and spent much of their time in the ambulance corps together. And then my uncle wrote home some letters to my grandfather saying that the French army was in mutiny, which was the case. The French were of course trying to conceal this because they wanted the Americans to come in. This is just at the time the Americans had declared war. And so the French didn't want to upset this so they were very disturbed that these letters were going back to the United States. They picked up my uncle and then they picked up Cummings because he was a friend. Now Cummings had done nothing, but Cummings would not say he loved the French better than the Germans and so they put him in jail and they put these two guys in this terrible prison in France, and kept them there. And eventually Cummings' father was well connected and through pull he got out and went home, and my uncle stayed there and almost died. And there were finally more connections. Also my great uncle had been on Woodrow Wilson's textile board, so they were able to make connections and get my uncle out and he came home, and Cummings'

father wanted him to write up what had happened so that he could sue the U.S. government, and Cummings said he wasn't going to have anything to do with that but that he would write it up as a compromise. So he and my uncle went up to Cummings' place in New Hampshire and Cummings wrote a book which turned out to be *The Enormous Room* which was his first important book in the career of e.e. cummings. So that's a fourth major book that the family has been responsible for by inadvertence.

MR: That's neat. You've been quite a catalyst.

JLC: So the members of my family, a lot of the members of my family were writers, but they really have not been much heard of. But by chance we were involved in some of these other things.

MR: Did you have a sense that you were going to be a writer even before you went to Hamilton?

JLC: No. I was surrounded by writers growing up. And I mean I knew people like Malcolm Cowley, I knew Matthew Josephson, I never really knew Cummings but I've met him, but the writers I basically knew were people like my father and my uncle and various others, who were commercial writers. And they were always broke. My idea of a writer was a man in a bathrobe weeping limp, telling the man from the finance company that the check was in the mail. I mean that was my idea of what a writer was. But nonetheless it was a very bookish family. This is the important thing. Not that we were terribly literary. My uncle did have ambitions to write novels and he did write a very good one eventually. But my father was basically concerned with seeing if he could make a living freelancing, which he really couldn't. So it was not so much that we were literary in that sense but we were very bookish going way back. If you look at the history of this you understand that the Massachusetts Bay Colony, which was far more important than the Plymouth people we hear so much about, the Bay Colony, they knew what they were doing, they knew how to make the thing work, they came over on a bunch of ships, they came over with oxen and plows and everything they needed but they were intellectual avante garde and a great many of them had come from Cambridge University in England and they had come over as an intellectual adventure as well as to build Golden Hill in the Golden City on the Hill in the wilderness and that sort of thing. They were interested in this intellectual side of it. And what they understood was that each person had to decide for himself precisely what God intended, and that meant you had to know *The Bible*. So that meant that everybody had to be able to read. There was more literacy in Massachusetts in the 1630s than there is in the United States today. These people could all read. And that tradition carried down through New England and that was the tradition I grew up in, a very bookish tradition. The people in my family who had money, and there were not very many of them, but the ones I knew who were able to live without working, they read —

there was just a routine of several hours a day reading. And if the weather were bad and you didn't have company to see or something, you might read all day long. Or if somebody were knitting and somebody else would be reading to them. You know it was just sort of books everywhere. And the great house that I was familiar with as a kid, my own family had no money, we were broke the whole time, but in my great aunt's house there were just books everywhere. And in the house I grew up in there were books everywhere. And people today in the current generation with the electronic media would find it very difficult to understand that in my family the five of us, my brother, my sister, myself and my parents, after dinner would all be sitting in the living room reading. And I don't mean we were all reading Trollope or Dickens or something, although my mother had three sets of Trollope and read Trollope endlessly. We might be reading *The Saturday Evening Post*. But we were reading.

MR: Instead of watching.

JLC: Instead of watching. So by the time — I was reading adult books by the time I was nine simply because they'd be lying there somewhere and I'd pick it up and start reading it. I was reading Rebelais when I was in high school, I was reading Dickens when I was in high school, just because the sets of the stuff were there. You wanted something to read, oh I think I'll read *Oliver Twist*.

MR: It must have prepared you pretty well for college studies?

JLC: Well it did. I was a very bad student. I mean I was goofing off, I was playing in the jazz band, I was drinking beer if I could ever put together ten cents for a beer I was running around and stuff. I managed to pass my courses by and large but yeah — although I didn't realize it, I came to Hamilton better read than probably most of the kids. But also my father had been very involved in — he was an autodidact. He had run away from home when he was 16 from a good family up on Cohasset, Massachusetts. And he had run away. And so he never really finished high school. So he didn't have a college, sort of a well-rounded as we'd say, college education. But what he did have was, he was very smart, and had intellectual curiosity. And he had gotten involved, he had had Freudian therapy in the 1930s, which he badly needed, and so he read a great deal of psychology. So by the time I went to college I also was somewhat versed in Freudian lore, hardly an authority on Freud mind you, but I mean these terms the unconscious and whatnot were all sort of stuff that I understood. And one of my first exams, Boba Rudd, the infamous Boba Rudd, English professor in my day, gave us an exam, a typical exam of the time, mentioning a couple of poems that we were supposed to have read and said please tell me what the intention of the poet was. And my response on the exam was we cannot know the intention of the poet because it's in the unconscious. And he gave me a zero. So I stopped pulling that stuff on him.

MR: You know on that kind of thing you're either going to get an A or you're going to get a zero.

JLC: I was a freshman you know, I was a freshman, my God. I was 18 years old, What did I know? But yeah for me it was a good background obviously to be well read. And I took it for granted that I was going to study English literature, which I did. I took I think all the courses in English literature that Hamilton offered at that time except Shakespeare which I figured I knew enough about anyway. And Howard Nemerov was my comp teacher, the great poet, well certainly well known poet, now dead. Howard was at Hamilton for several years and was teaching English comp and he wrote a novel when he was up there, I think called *Dance Out the Answer* which probably is kicking around and was an academic novel and how much of it bore on Hamilton I have no idea but he was there. So I had that literary background. But I never, I didn't know what I wanted to do. I had graduated from college and I owed some money. I'd never managed to pay my bills. And so I knew that I had to work that off. So I got a job just cutting lawns and whatever, some physical labor to earn some money and pay that off and then get on with it. Well of course the Korean War started within a week after graduation. So within a couple of months I was gone. And fortunately I never got sent to Korea because I would have been dead meat, because that was right at the beginning. I mean it would have been very, very bad. That was a very bad war, very bad. But I was on the list to go three times, and I had shots, I had the whole series of shots for the Far East. And every time, at the last minute they piled the guys in the truck and the Sergeant would be calling out everybody's name and I'd still be standing there. Three times I was left there. And I can only think that they knew that the government had got me pinpointed because too many of the members of my family were Communists. And my aunt, I have on good testimony, was a card carrying member of the Communist party, but I know for sure she was cited by the House Un-American Activities Committee in 1939. So she was a public figure to some extent. She'd been involved in politics in New York City, she'd been involved with all sorts of, you know, the Milk Committee and that kind of thing, the Consumers Committee and various things of that kind. And my uncle was an editor first on the *New Republic* and then on the *New Masses*. So all of this was public. And I can only assume that this was in my dossier somewhere and they weren't going to send me.

MR: I was thinking, if I do the math right, according to your birthdate, you almost would have been draftable at the end of World War II, right?

JLC: I missed it by a year.

MR: By a year, okay. Can you recall back then thinking that that was going to be a possibility if this war doesn't wind down or end? Was that a concern of yours?

JLC: Well it wasn't a concern. When I was 14 years old I was afraid the war would be over before I could get into it. You know, I was a kid. I wanted to be a glory boy, I wanted to fly airplanes, I wanted whatever it was. Because you remember, I was brought up on World War I pop literature. You were always reading — you remember World War I, during the thirties, when I was a kid, reading comic books and reading magazines and reading just kids books and whatever, the war that you read about was the first World War and the brave marines at The Somme or whatever it was, and the Red Baron flying the airplanes and so forth. So that was the romance of the war, it was sort of part of what you grew up with if you were a boy in my generation. Now my father was very anti-war of course, and he was always talking about the merchants of death and so forth, because they were all left wing and hated all of this and they were older and had actually known what the war was about. So for me, and then by the time I got to be a senior in high school, or a junior and senior in high school, it was clear that the war was going to be over. We knew that that was a dead issue. And so the likelihood of fighting, there were some of my friends who were just enough older, did get drafted and served in what they called the Constabulate. They were occupation forces in Germany and some in Japan and whatever. So I never particularly worried about that so I didn't think I was going to go. We didn't know there was going to be a Korean conflict.

MR: Well as long as we're in this sort of part of your life, do you remember what it cost to go to Hamilton at the time?

JLC: I think it was three hundred bucks a semester. And then you had your room and board and that depended, because it was a bad situation at Hamilton at that time. You had sixty percent of the students who were in fraternities and forty percent were not. Now if you go to a place like Harvard where they had the Persallion and the fancy clubs, only a small fracture of the student body belonged to the clubs so you could ignore them. And if you went to places where they had a universal rushing policy, where everybody had to join if they wanted, then that was also a question. But at Hamilton you had the haves and the have nots so to speak. And it was always, there was always a problem about that. And I was — coming from a left wing family, see I didn't belong at Hamilton. I wasn't the right guy for Hamilton at all. It was a conservative school. There's a wonderful story, in 1948 Truman of course won in that famous election where they all thought Dewey was going to win, but in fact there were only, in my fraternity, which was ELS, there were only two of us who were Democrats. One of them was a southern kid named Mort Sams, who was president of the house and I was Board Steward. And so we put out for the others, we put out cookies and coffee, and I had that all there and said "Well you guys are going to have a good time tonight." But I sat up. And after around midnight I began thinking uh oh, something going on here. And finally by two or three in the morning it was becoming

clear that not only was Truman likely to win but we were going to have a Democratic congress. And I don't think it was really until six or seven in the morning that it was finally decided. And so at nine o'clock in the morning some rascal went over and rang the chapel bell, as if it had been a football victory. And the dean, Dean Tolles, came flying out of his office shouting, "God damn it, I don't care who won the election but God damn it this is a Republican college."

MR: Is that right?

JLC: I think it was Dean Tolles. It was one of them, either him or somebody else in the administration. But I was an old leftie, I had all this sort of Freudian thing in my background, and I had a lot — there were a lot of pre-ministerial students, I was an atheist, and these guys would just look at me as if I were a very strange creature. And they'd say, "Jim, you're a nice guy, how can you be an atheist?" You know, that sort of thing.

MR: Oh. Did you have chapel every day?

JLC: I think you had chapel on Sunday, yes.

MR: Yeah, okay.

JLC: And I think you had three chapels a week. I'm not sure, you'd have to check.

MR: And this is something you were supposed to go to? You were required to go?

JLC: Oh you had to. You were allowed three cuts. It was like anything else. I think you were allowed three cuts a semester, in a course, and chapel was the same. You got three cuts. By the time I was a junior some of us had said, "Well look, we're atheists, what's this Sunday chapel?" So they allowed us to have a meeting, a philosophic meeting with one of the professors, I've forgotten who, to take the place of that. But we had to do something, you know, we couldn't opt out.

MR: Yeah. Well on top of all those things that you were, you were also a jazz guy.

JLC: Well that's probably more to the point here. You got me wandering around.

MR: No but I enjoy hearing about — of course I should tell — my daughter went to Hamilton, she just graduated last May so I really enjoy hearing about what it was like back then.

JLC: Yeah, well Hamilton was a conservative college, and it still is. And did you know Dean Alfange, a member of my class? I hadn't seen Dean since I graduated. I went back for my fiftieth, and Dean came over and said "Jim, I don't know whether you remember me." And I said "sure Dean, nice to see you." And we sat and talked and drank a glass of wine and he had said something nice about one of my books. And I asked, because his father had been head of the — I'm not sure, one of the labor parties, whether it was the American Labor Party or something, but he had been very much on the left, a Labor guy, like me. And I said "Dean, how did you end up here at Hamilton." And he said "my dad

went here." So that was somebody I think had sponsored him, an immigrant or something like this sponsored him and he came. I mean you'd have to ask Dean the details.

MR: Well you said if you could get ten cents together for a glass of beer. Now where would you go for a glass of beer at Hamilton?

JLC: There was a — well remember all of the fraternity houses had bars and there was always a beer party somewhere, or maybe more than one, on Saturday night. And those were pretty much open houses. If it were a closed party I don't remember that happening a lot but pretty much anyone could come. And the fraternity was — our fraternity whatever — you bought three or four kegs of beer, whatever it was, that's pretty much all you had, beer. And everybody would come. And what was interesting about this is that what you did very often at these beer parties was sing. In those days everybody sang. People knew how to sing. I'm a terrible singer. Guys in my band won't even let me sing "Happy Birthday" when we're asked to do it. But people sang. And you would always find, in any group of people — young people, old people, whatever — people who knew the harmonies to all kinds of songs, Folk songs, pop songs, whatever. So there was a lot more, because you didn't have so much mechanical music, there was a lot more making of music by human beings in those days than there was, and that goes back to high school. In high school we'd go to a party and people would sing, and that's what would be happening generally at these beer parties, there'd be a lot of singing, maybe there would be a band, maybe our band would be playing, but mostly not. Bands were too expensive. So that was what people did. So there was a lot of music around. But there was a place down at the foot of the hill — was it called — I can't remember what it was called — but that was the main place. It was a little bar.

MR: A bar.

JLC: It was a little, like and they had pig's knuckles in a jar and boiled eggs in a jar, and ten cent beers, and the locals would drink there but a lot of college guys would drink there. The guys who had money would go over to the Alexander Hamilton Inn and drink martinis. But those of us who didn't have any money, we'd go down there and drink beer. And now you remember, I'm still carrying on about — we should get on to jazz — but see Hamilton was a very different place when I was there. Eighty percent of my freshman class were vets so that what you had at Hamilton at that time was a whole bunch of guys who were older, who had started college and had got drafted and some of these guys were combat veterans, some of these guys were South Pacific veterans and they'd come back and now they're 22 years old and maybe even married. So they were setting the tone, these older guys. And they weren't going to have freshman beanies or any of that stuff. That wasn't going to happen.

MR: They'd wear helmets before that.

JLC: Yeah they weren't doing any of that stuff. But in my class you had a lot of guys who had got drafted right at the end of the war, as we were saying, and had been serving, maybe they served for a year or for six months, whatever, and were released because they were discharging everybody. This was 1946, they were discharging everybody, get them out, because our government didn't want to pay for their —

MR: Oh I didn't know that, that you might have gone in for just a year and then got —

JLC: At that time, yes.

MR: Okay.

JLC: They were disbanding the Army, get rid of them, get rid of them, and send everybody home. So people were getting out and I remember John Fell, who was the clarinet player in our band, John was in a situation like this, he'd only been in for a while but he was a very bright guy and he could type and — which was not so usual in those days — and he was a clerk somewhere in the Army, and the order came through that if you could go back to college immediately you could be discharged. So he pulled out a form and typed it up and put it in and went home. And so guys were getting out. So my freshman class was filled with these guys who had only been in for a short period of time.

MR: They called that the "crazy mixed up years" didn't they?

JLC: Well no, that was the years just before us. Because by the time 1946, the war is over, we're coming into a peacetime situation, the college has increased in size — it was the years before when people were coming and going and they would come for a year or come for a year and a half, come for six months, get drafted, and then come back. And that was the crazy mixed up years. Ours had started back to normality — and the word is not normalcy — normality again, and we had sort of it was back to normal, except we had all these guys who had seen it all, and there was a big rule that you didn't tell war stories. There was a whole thing about that, you did not.

MR: No kidding.

JLC: I've known a lot of — over the course of my life obviously — a lot of guys my age more or less who were combat vets. They don't talk about it. They just don't. It's too difficult in many ways. You don't want to show off, that was another thing. And I played jazz with a guy called Flip Don Phillips who died recently. And Don I knew for twenty years. And he was in combat in France and I never knew anything about that until the last couple of years of his life. He just never talked about it. So that was the situation there. Now I'll segue into jazz. I got up to Hamilton at that time when you were admitted they sent you a form which was sent around to the fraternities and, I don't know, you put down whatever you were that might appeal to the fraternities. And I had a lot: I was on the baseball team, I was in the band, I was on the — what else, I was president of my class for a couple of years, I was on the yearbook, the newspaper, whatever. I had all

those sorts of things that always looked good to fraternity people. But I was a left wing guy. I wasn't going to send this paper in. So I never — the fraternities just didn't even know I existed, which is what I wanted. I mean I didn't want to have anything to do with that, which I didn't know anything about fraternities, but I just assumed they must be bad. And they were in a lot of ways. But I got up there and it turned out I had a cousin who I didn't know, in fact had never heard of, but somebody told me you have your cousin up there, and he was one of these older guys who had been in combat. And he had been told off by his parents, "Now you have to go over and look up Jim Collier, your young cousin." So he came and got me and he invited me over to the ELS house, which was then it was an independent house. It didn't have any national affiliation. But it was basically a fraternity like any of the rest of them, although we did try to keep out grades up, I mean there was some point to that. And so he was showing me around the house, "Would you like to see our rooms" and so he took me into his room and here's all this array of 78 jazz records. Here's Bix Beiderbecke, here's the Billy Banks Rhythm Makers, here's Louis Armstrong, here's Bessie Smith. And my eyes popped open because when I went to high school I was the only kid in high school who knew anything about jazz. And so — well not quite, but I mean you know — and, "You guys like this stuff?" And he ran down the hall and got a couple of his buddies and they came over and the next thing I know I'm listening to records with these guys. And so that was a done deal. So then they asked me to join ELS and I did. So that was — so to me there was sort of a jazz component to that. I think there's something — I think I ought to tell you, this is another thing that's not quite apropos to what we were talking about, but I think this ought to be on record. This is an important story. When my class had its fiftieth reunion I wrote to, I've forgotten who it was the class annalist, somebody there who writes the annals, whatever, and I said this is a story that you really ought to focus on. At that time Hamilton was admitting one black per class. And that is correct. And in my class there was a boy/man, whatever you want to say, student called Ace Lawrence, out of a class of 150, one black, and he was immediately elected president of the class. Nobody knew anything about him but that was the way it was. And somebody taxed the administration office about that and was told no, no, we would be glad to take two or three blacks if we could find them. Now that was the situation. With Jews it was different. Jews, there were quite a number of Jews, and ELS house, which had no national affiliation, we could take whoever we wanted and we did have Jewish kids in our fraternity, that was not an issue. But many of the fraternities had clauses in their charters which said they could not take Jews. That was spelled out. They had to be Christians. Everyone had to be Christians. And so I'm going to tell two stories. And somewhere during these years, I don't know whether it would have been '48 or somewhere around in there, a kid was pledged to one

of the houses — Lambda Chi I guess — and it came to the final signing up and there was — he had to sign a statement saying he was a Christian. And he looked at these guys and said, "But I can't sign this, I'm Jewish." And they said, "Well we didn't know and we didn't care" but they said, "we're stuck." So they called up the Theta Delta House, the president, they called the president of the Theta Delta House and said, "Hey we've got a situation here, can you do something about it?" And so Theta Delta called the national organization and said, "We've got a Jewish kid we want to take." And they said no. Can't do it. And they said, "Fine, we're resigning from the national organization." And the national backed down and they took this guy.

MR: This was 1946, your first year?

JLC: No, this would have been later, after I was maybe a junior or something, '48, somewhere around in there. But during that time I and three or four or five or six other members of my house, because there were no blacks in any fraternity and hardly any blacks on the campus mind you, but there were no blacks in any fraternity. And we said, this group of us said, we're going to do something about this. And so there was a young freshman called Don Thomas and last I heard he was living in New York on the Upper West Side, and Don was a big, good looking guy, had come from Oberlin. His father had been I think the postmaster in Oberlin, and had grown up in a circumstance where blacks were pretty well accepted because Oberlin was one of the first colleges in the United States to take blacks, and so it was a whole different situation he had grown up in. And I guess his dad wanted him to go to some other place so that he'd get a little taste what the real world was like. But he was a big, good looking guy, he was athletic, he went out for basketball, he was a happy-go-lucky guy, he liked to drink beer, he was a party boy. He was a classic fraternity guy. Absolutely the guy, had he been white, all of the fraternities would have been giving him bids. But they didn't. And so finally I said look — or here's — one of us — I don't want to take all the credit for all of this. I said we've got to, this guy is a guy who you can't think of any reason for turning him down. You can't say he's too short, you can't say he's a nerd, you can't say anything about him. And so we put him up, and we fought. And it took us a couple of months to fight that through the fraternity. Fortunately in ELS we didn't have a black ball system. You had a majority vote. So if the majority wanted him, and it took us a struggle to get the majority, but we did get that majority, and so we broke the color line in the fraternity system there at Hamilton. And once he was in the house it was a done deal. Nobody cared. The party guys in the house, they immediately took to him. They were all out running around drinking beer and not doing their homework. I was Don's upper class advisor so I was always sticking it to him saying come on, you put your tail down in that chair and let's see — I want to see these grades. But the unhappy result was that all of the other houses breathed a sigh of relief

saying ELS is going to take care of the blacks, and so we had a moral crisis over every black kid that was admitted to Hamilton after that. But I think it helped the administration to see that the students were not going to have a problem with this, they just weren't. And so then of course things began to change and the situation began to open up and obviously improve. But I wanted that on record.

MR: It's an excellent story.

JLC: That was what you had at Hamilton in those days. And it was obviously time to change.

MR: You mentioned you didn't have a black ball system. How do you black ball somebody?

JLC: Well a blackball goes back to the old business of joining a club I think in London where you had the white balls and a blackball and if you favored the admission you threw the white ball in so it was all secret. But if you threw a blackball in and if there were a blackball in the bowl then it was no.

MR: So one person could block it.

JLC: That's right. I think in practice it didn't quite work that way because at the beginning of the year the houses were competing with each other to get the people they considered to be the most desirable. So you had a committee. And the committee generally was empowered to make decisions. But later in the year if you were going to take in additional people, maybe you were going to take in a sophomore for example, who suddenly everybody liked or thought why isn't he in this or whatever, somebody was promoting. But then you would have a voting system.

MR: I see.

JLC: So originally the committee, the committee had to be able to act rapidly because some other house is going to grab this guy so, you know, so you would.

MR: Fascinating. Tell me about playing jazz at Hamilton.

JLC: Well yeah, now there's a lot to be said about all of that. If you read the jazz history books you do not understand that what was called Dixieland jazz, what we probably call classic jazz or trad jazz or something of that kind, was the most popular form of jazz in the United States. You had, beginning in around 1936, you began to have the so-called Dixieland revival. And I won't go into all the detail of that because it'd take too long. But you began having these bands, people as a result of the swing boom there was a sense that the public was ready for a hotter kind of music. There had been a hot music in the 1920s, then came the depression and hot music was in trouble, now the hot music is back again. And a lot of the players said hey we can maybe, we don't have to sit in the swing bands, maybe we can go out and play the kind of music we originally came into music to play. And so you began having these bands — on the west coast you had Lu Watters and so forth and those bands playing real, going back to Oliver and going back to Armstrong Hot Fives and so forth. In the sound you had people digging up Bunk Johnson and those

guys and bringing them out. And around the northeast it was more the Condon group with the Wild Bill Davison with George Brunies, Pee Wee Russell and Hall, Bobby Hackett, Teagarden, you know, those names. And so by the late thirties, early forties, if you were interested in jazz it was this, it was Dixieland jazz, or whatever term you want to use. And you began to score in the swing bands. Now Benny Goodman, aww come on, that's swing. It was these Condon bands or the Lu Watters band or Bunk Johnson or whatever it was, Sidney Bechet had had this big revival. Whatever it was, that was it. And this was what the dyed in the wool, the serious jazz fan, was listening to. Not the dance bands. Not the Harry James. Not anything like that. It was this.

MR: Was that considered, did they use the word "commercial"?

JLC: Yeah it was commercial.

MR: Okay.

JLC: Oh yeah it was commercial. This is commercial crap. And a lot of the baby got thrown out with the bath water a good deal of the time. But you have to remember if you listen to the best of Benny Goodman or the best of Count Basie or the best of Duke Ellington, whatever, you hear a lot of wonderful stuff. If you listen to a complete, the complete Bunny Berigan for example, you hear one dreary dance tune after the next. One after the next. One after the next, with a vocal and so forth and so on. So that the percentage of really good jazz that was being played by those bands was, in some cases, maybe fifty percent. Maybe in the case of say a Goodman or Basie, it might be half. But in the case of a lot of these bands it was a quarter or a third or none. So that a lot of standard swing band stuff was really not of appeal to jazz fans. So that was commercial. Over here was the pure stuff. And right at the same time, because of a lot of factors partly having to do with the war and to the strike, Putrillo's strike of the musician's union, there were a lot of reissue programs going out. So now you could go down to a store and buy an album which was an album with four or five or three records in it.

MR: Ten inch?

JLC: Ten inch records, or in some cases twelve, mostly ten inch records, of eight Bix Beiderbecke things or eight sides of Armstrong or eight sides of Jelly Roll Morton.

MR: Oh yeah, I see, when you say an album, you mean multiple records.

JLC: Right.

MR: That's right. Because Milt Fillius had given a bunch of those things. I forget that an album originally meant multiple records.

JLC: It was an album. These albums originally developed for classical music because if you wanted to have an opera, even on a twelve inch record, a twelve inch record is only going to play four and a half minutes of music on each side, nine minutes — if you've got an opera how many records are you going to need? So even if you excerpted them — or the

nine Beethoven symphonies that Toscanini did. These were in albums. They were in books with a hard cover and sleeves that, it was all together. So they began putting the jazz in these albums, these reissue programs. So we were listening, we were now ten, twelve, fourteen, sixteen years old and we were listening to the Hot Fives and we were listening to Beiderbecke, we were listening to Morton, we were listening to Oliver, we were listening to the Ben Pollock Orchestra, you know, the band with Teagarden and Goodman, we were listening to all that stuff as well as the new records that were coming out, which were originally on Commodore, Blue Note, small labels of that kind, with Hackett, with Russell, with Teagarden, with Joe Sullivan, with Jess Stacy, with Davison and Brunies and all of these people who became our heroes. These were the heroes. And all through the United States, but particularly in the Northeast we had radio programs. We had the famous Eddie Condon Saturday afternoon from Town Hall, his program, so that kids all over and around the New York area, Saturday afternoon was sacred. You had to listen to the Eddie Condon show.

MR: Was there a distinction with you guys in your listening between black and white bands or black and white artists?

JLC: Nobody even knew. Nobody cared. The black and white thing didn't exist. It did not exist. You were — you know Johnny Hodges would be, you know everybody's favorite alto player. Nobody ever heard of a baritone sax player better than Harry Carney. Louis of course. But you would listen to Louis and you would turn around and listen to Beiderbecke who was white. You would listen to Jack Teagarden and you'd turn around and listen to Dickie Wells who was black. You'd listen to the great black saxophone player, Coleman Hawkins, Lester Young, all these guys. There was no problem. If you looked at a typical collection of records from somebody from those days they'd be completely mixed. Completely mixed. Billy Banks Rhythm Makers, that was a mixed band. They had black and white guys in it. It was a recording band only, but it was mixed. You didn't know the difference.

MR: How many people in your fraternity had record players?

JLC: Well I think a lot of them did. A lot of them did. And then there was a big fancy record player in the living room. So before lunch we'd all be down there playing Hot Fives or something or other, Pee Wee Russell, who knows, arguing about who was better. You had all of Pee Wee Russell. Typical stuff. But you see this, if you read the histories, you go right from the swing bands, where they say this is the only time jazz was popular in the United States, most of that wasn't jazz. That's completely wrong. You go right from there to bebop, to Bird and — but the main thing during those years from say the very late thirties through most of the fifties, say until '55 or somewhere up in there, was this Dixieland jazz was the most popular. That — Bird and Diz were being recorded by small

labels, by Dial, by amateur guys who scraped together enough money to make a record. Condon was being recorded by Decca. Some of these bands, Hackett was being recorded by Columbia. So these are on mainstream albums.

MR: It'd be much less likely then for a college band formed by students to be playing what you're describing rather than bebop. It would be unlikely for a college band at that time to get together to play bebop, is that what you're kind of saying?

JLC: Well in the first place we couldn't. I mean.

MR: Right, it was too—

JLC: But at Hamilton we never heard of bebop. We were up there. We were up on that hill up there. Who knew from bebop? So number one, up until the late forties there really wasn't a lot of awareness of bebop except in very, very, like people, kids who were living in New York City and could get to 52nd Street occasionally and hear it. So there was not that much awareness. In the second place, when you did hear it you heard Bird and Diz playing at those high tempos and playing these funny changes. I mean you just right away knew you couldn't do it. So that most of these college bands were playing Dixieland because it was the same harmonic structure that you were learning in your music appreciation course from Bach.

MR: Or singing those songs.

JLC: Right.

MR: Some of those songs that you guys would sing that had sort of the same structures.

JLC: Well it was all standard stuff, it was all 32-bar tunes, it was all that. And harmonic structure you could figure out pretty much the chord changes and the chord changes were all pretty simple. And you could learn to play well enough to do it. And so the consequence was that all over the Northeast you had these amateur college Dixieland bands. Everywhere. The Crimson Stompers at Harvard, Tigertown Five at Princeton, Eli's Chosen Six at Yale. You had a band at Amherst, you had a band at Williams, you had Hamilton, Cornell, you know, everywhere you had these bands. And I know that there was a similar thing going on on the West Coast. What was going on in the south and the Midwest I don't know. It could very well have been the same thing was happening at Vanderbilt, was happening at Tulane, I don't know. Somebody would have to look into that. But I do know because a lot of the guys that — the cadre of musicians who were playing this kind of music my age around New York, most of these guys had played in some college band somewhere. So I know that, you know, what they were doing. And what happened at Hamilton was there was a Irishman named Jack Kelly and Jack was a trumpet player, a terrible trumpet player, and I had gone up to Hamilton without my trombone but I brought it back after Christmas holiday. And Jack and I would go down to the ELS basement and drink beer and make this perfectly hideous noise you

know. We thought we were playing the blues, God knows it was terrible. But then I began to meet guys around the campus who were interested in jazz because you'd be drawn together with people like that just by chance and by the next year we had a little band: Mike Beldock on drums — Mike went on to be an important defense attorney. He was the one who got Hurricane Carter out of jail — Myron Beldock. And his partner, Elliot Abrams is a big music lawyer — not Elliot Abrams, Elliot Hoffman was a big music lawyer who represented George Wein, represented the Newport Jazz Festival, represented Dizzy, Jimmy Rushing and so forth. So they had kind of a little jazz law firm there. And John Fell was a clarinet player and John went on to be an important authority on film, particularly early film, and was head of the film department at San Francisco State. And Pete Zeeveldt, when we first met him he was a year or two behind us, Pete could only play in C but we made him move over a little bit so we had — and then the key figure was Bob Krompart. Bob is quite a good trumpet player for what he was, for a college. And his dad had been a musician and played with The Buffalodians, which was the band from Buffalo that Harold Arlen had started out in. And so — and Bob could play pretty well. I have records, I have a couple of home made records that we made of this. And we had a bass player very briefly but Wally Alpren, who went on to become a federal judge, was guitar player. And so there were six of us: myself, John — yeah that was it. That was the group. And we practiced every week. We had a weekly practice. And then we played fraternity parties, we did get some gigs off campus. I know we played Union from time to time, a couple of times anyway, we played at Colgate, I don't know how often, we played at Wells, we played at RPI, I think we played at Ithaca College maybe, I'm not sure. But we were playing around a little bit. I think we got five bucks a man then. But it wasn't a very good band.

MR: It was a lot of fun I'll bet.

JLC: It was a lot of fun. It was something that we did and something that we wanted to do.

MR: Give me two or three songs that would have been on your playlist.

JLC: Well we played all those standard things, "Muskrat Ramble" and "The Saints Go Marching In," and "Black and Blue" and oh the blues of course and probably "Memphis Blues," I can't remember exactly. There was one we used to do all the time called "She Looks Like Helen Brown." I've never heard of it since. I could probably still play it if I had to.

MR: Did the college have any input, any opinion, any other thing to do with what you were doing?

JLC: No the college was bemused. The college thought jazz, well that's a rather funny sort of thing and we don't know anything about it and they had no interest in it really at all.

MR: How about the music professors?

JLC: Well I took the music appreciation course. There was a guy called Berrian Shute, and he was very good. It was a very good course and I learned chord changes, I learned harmony, I learned basic Western harmony from this course. And that was how I began to get my changes together and I realized hey, there's a whole scheme here that you could know. And so I — but they had no interest in jazz whatever. None. This was an odd little hobby like who knows what, collecting pottery or something or other that some of the students had. That was alright but nobody was going to encourage it.

MR: I don't know if you would have ever had this conversation with your bandmates or your listening mates, but do you recall if you thought of this music at the time as an art form?

JLC: Oh yeah sure. I mean everyone was calling it an art form. I mean you can go back to the early 1920s there were critics who were calling it an art form. This was major critics. Critics for the *New York Times* used the word art in respect to jazz in the early 1920's. So this was sort of understood it was an art form. But it was underground. The kids today of course see jazz as part of the establishment, and you know this is bad news, this is not merely your father's music but your grandfather's music. And so that's a sort of an establishment thing. But we were like rock & roll guys in the fifties. We were the underground. We were the rebels. We were the outsiders. That was the way you felt about yourself and that's the way you felt about jazz. And it was partly true. It depended where you were. In New York City no, I mean there was a lot of jazz around. But there was a good jazz club in Utica though, Tommy Jordie's.

MR: Oh really?

JLC: Yeah, I remember hearing some pretty good piano players up there if I could ever afford to go up there, which — Tommy Jordie's. I remember hearing Joe Sullivan who was one of our heroes in — a piano player up there, a lot of piano players used to go through that place. So there was some jazz up there but basically no. There was a black club we used to go up and sit in with some of these guys. I remember the drummer had wooden leg.

MR: Oh my God.

JLC: I don't know how he managed but he did. And we used to go and sit in there and I think they were bemused as well at these young white kids coming in there and banging around on our instruments the way we did.

MR: Well I think it's got to have great importance that you did that and that you're still doing it and that you were inspired to write about jazz.

JLC: Well yes you know as I say I didn't know what I was going to do when I got out of college but then by the time I realized I was going to get out of the Army I knew I had to make up my mind and I just sort of said well I guess you're going to be a writer. That was sort of like it seemed fated. Nothing ever occurred to me that I ought to do anything

else. And I didn't look forward to it with great glee. I wasn't saying oh boy I'm going to be the next Proust or something of that kind, because I'd seen too much of it.

MR: You didn't have any like pie in the sky ideas.

JLC: No, I knew what it was and while I wanted, like all of my people of my generation, you all wanted to be Ernest Hemingway, you know, chicks, the Riviera—

MR: A boat, fishing.

JLC: Right. Great business. But so I set out to be a writer and I've never looked back and I've never felt sorry and I struggled like anyone else beginning to get published, and eventually I did get published and then I began writing for the magazines and to make — I had a wife and children and all the rest of the nonsense that goes along with twenty-first century America. And I had — to make a living I was writing for the magazines. By the time I'd been doing for, I don't know four or five years, five or six years, I was writing for all the top magazines, the big six women's magazines: *Redbook, Cosmopolitan,* Vanity — not *Vanity Fair, Glamour, Esquire, The New Republic, Sports Illustrated, Reader's Digest, Playboy, Penthouse*, all of them.

MR: They would call you with assignments or would you submit ideas?

JLC: It worked both ways. I mean you're always looking, you've got to make sure you've got some work. So if they called you great. Hey Jim would you be interested in thus and so. If they didn't call you you'd be out hustling. Hey Charlie I'm going to be in town on Wednesday I thought I might drop by, whatever, see what you can get. But I never wanted to do that. My father had been in the magazine business, my uncle I mean knew a lot of that magazine business. It wasn't interesting. I mean I take that back. You did a lot of interesting things. I did a lot of travel eventually, not at the beginning. Eventually I was going to all sorts of places and meeting a lot of people that I wanted to meet. I've met a lot of movie stars and all of that, but that goes with the territory. But basically what I was interested in, I was very interested in social sciences and if I knew somebody had done a study on something or other I was interested and I'd cook up a story where I could bring him in. And then I'd get a free ticket to go down to New Orleans and interview the guy at Tulane you know, or whatever. So there was a lot of fun in a lot of that. But the writing itself was not challenging. I could sit down and knock that stuff out in a morning. It was nothing. And so all the time I was also developing some of these other kinds of things, particularly my children's books which I got into simply because some agent, Lynn Nesbit who went on to become quite a well known agent, Lynn suggested I start doing this. And the children's books became what certainly is important of what I've written, not the jazz stuff. I mean the jazz stuff, that's fine and it's good and I'm proud of it, but the children's stuff, I've sold millions of copies of the stuff and not only that I've been able to write the so-called prize winning, the quality kind of children's book that is

difficult and is interesting and is challenging and still make a living from it. And that to me has been the great blessing, that I could write and have reached the point now and have been at this point for some years where I can call my own shots. I write when I want to write and I generally manage to get paid for enough of it so that I can keep going with it.

MR: I brought one of the many *With Every Drop of Blood* book you wrote with your brother Christopher. And I wonder sometimes if you're going to write about the Civil War where does your research come from? Where do you go to try to write authentic battle scenes and those kinds of specific things?

JLC: Well the story is this. Most of my children's books I write by myself but I did I think eight with my brother. My brother recently retired but he was an American historian at the University of Connecticut and he was the State Historian for Connecticut, a very good historian. And so we started writing together and the first book we had was called *My Brother Sam is Dead* and it was an enormous success, it won all the prizes and everything. And still sells a hundred thousand copies a year, which is a lot less money than you think because it's an inexpensive paperback, but still. So he does the research. And he comes to me with a pile of material and says "here it is." And with a general story outline, a very brief story outline that's based on the historical events. But then I generally do some research and I know for this book, a Civil War book, I went down to Gettysburg obviously, and I went to some of the other battle areas to look at those and I went to whatever museums there were that seemed appropriate. Because you want to get a look at the uniforms, you want to get a look at the swords, at the rifles, you want to get a look at the cannons, you want to take pictures whatever you do. You want to get a look at Gettysburg, you want to see what that looks like. You want to see what those hills are and the valley in between and over here you had the north and over here you had Lee with his bunch, and so you want to do that. But the bulk of the research is done by my brother, and then I take it and write a story about it. So that's how that works.

MR: That's wonderful. Like a lot of writers you get your share of criticism and praise. And I'm wondering do you think some of the criticism you've got is because you don't engage in what I would call sort of hero worship?

JLC: Well yeah. I mean I don't really want to discuss my critics and the criticism that's been leveled, but yes. You're just simply not supposed to treat Duke Ellington or Louis Armstrong, both of whom I've written about, the same way that, you know, as if they were human beings. They have to be Gods and Goddesses if you're writing about Billie Holiday, and I was told flatly that you can't write about a black the same way you write about a white. Now that's racism. That is simply saying that a black cannot stand up to the criticism that a white can. And I'm saying no, that's not true. When my — I got a

great deal of criticism for my Ellington book particularly but also for the Armstrong book. When my Benny Goodman book came out, here is a white Jew, my editor recently departed, Sheldon Myer, regretfully, went to some of these people, some of whom were his own authors and said, "Look Jim treated Benny just the way he treated Louis and Duke." And they all said, "It doesn't matter."

MR: No kidding.

JLC: They don't care. You can say anything you want about Benny. He made a lot of money, so did Duke make more money than Benny ever did, but he spent it all. But you can't take that approach. You have people today who write about — leading authorities — on Duke Ellington write about "Creole Love Call" as if Duke wrote it. Duke didn't write it, he stole it from King Oliver. And this isn't anything anyone can even question. You go back and listen to the Oliver record, which is called "Camp Meeting Blues," it's not merely that Duke took the tune, he took the arrangement. It's the same arrangement. He doctored it a little bit, it's got the same second theme, it's the same thing. And yet they're still writing about it as if Duke wrote the tune. Now come on, man, you're a scholar. You're supposed to be telling what appears to be the truth. And they're not doing it. They're not doing it. They refuse to do it. And it's racial, that's what it is.

MR: Is it political correctness gone amok?

JLC: Well of course. I mean and it's a problem so that the consequence, as we were talking about the Dixieland stuff has been left out of jazz histories, why? Because it was mostly a white movement. There were plenty of blacks involved, sure. One of my favorite trumpet players, Joe Thomas, who is not known at all, Joe was black, he was playing with these guys, We know he was playing with these guys, there were others. But it was principally, most of the players were white. But they were playing music that had been originated by blacks. They were playing the original New Orleans music. And today it's scorned because it's — and the one great joke is that Marsalis finally broke down and had a New Orleans type band in one of his concerts and it was the black — White — what's his name down in the New Orleans band, Doctor —

MR: Oh yes.

JLC: I've forgotten.

MR: I have forgotten too but I know who you mean. Oh White, I forget his first name. He plays clarinet I think.

JLC: Yeah a clarinet player. And there are a lot of white bands around that are much better than his band. I remember hearing that band down there once, some people took me out to hear the band and they asked me after the first set, "What do you think?" And I said, "Well the trumpet player's having a lot of trouble with the changes." And they looked at me and said, "Yeah that's what people are saying." Because he — I won't get into it. But

that is the point, that jazz history has been falsified to a considerable extent because of the effort being made to write whites out of it, that the whites really don't matter. The fact of the matter is the primary audience has always been white. If you didn't have whites you wouldn't have had jazz as an audience. It would have been a small hobby that would have long since disappeared.

MR: When you go to the jazz parties now that play I guess what we would call classic jazz, you see very few black musicians playing at these parties.

JLC: There are very few black musicians playing this kind of music. Where you will find them is in New Orleans where you'll find some blacks saying hey this is our heritage why aren't we playing this and then they do start to play it. But I've played certainly with black players, I've had them in bands that I've been in. I've played with Manzie Johnson who was with — I think played with Louis and he also played with Jelly Roll Morton. I've played Arvell Shaw who was with Louis. I've played with — well you know, several blacks. In one of mine — an early band that I was in we had a guy named Walter Bow, a young black guy of our generation who was our regular trumpet player. But they're rare. You don't find black players who are interested in playing this kind of music, so you don't have them. And there would be no problem. There are older black guys around who sometimes you find — I mean at The Cajun when I was playing there you had some black players there — Freddy Moore, you know, guys like that.

MR: We're going to be running out of tape soon. But this is a great conversation. I wanted to — a couple of things you wrote, one thing I really just want to say is a great little description you wrote of the sixth chorus on Ellington's recording of "Koko," you described it as "sounds as if we were opening and closing a door on a cocktail party."

JLC: Did I say that?

MR: You said that. That was a good description.

JLC: It sounds very nice. I'll have to bear that in mind.

MR: You've managed to keep playing. Do you have a steady gig?

JLC: Yeah actually I'm very lucky. I have two steady gigs. Our band has been playing — with Dick Sherman's band — at the Donnell Library which is over here on 53rd Street, a half a block from here. We've been playing there since 1976 every Thursday 12:30 'till 2:00 and off for the summers but we've been there all that time. And we have a nice crowd that comes it. It's a beautiful little auditorium, one of the nicest auditoriums, small auditoriums in New York. The acoustics are marvelous. And they have a great big Steinway grand piano for us so we can always get piano players.

MR: It's like a lunchtime sort of concert?

JLC: It's a concert. It's a concert. It's a jazz concert. People come in who are either on their lunch break or retired people who are looking for something to do. And then also we

were at The Cajun for 14 years which was a club, the last club in New York that featured classic jazz seven nights a week, and we also played there Wednesday at lunch. And they closed it down in August, they're going to pull a building down. The place was making money and had good audiences, but they're going to pull the building down and put up condos so that's what happens. So I was able, luckily, to find another little restaurant in Greenwich Village called Greenwich Village Bistro and we can only — it's a small room, we can only do a trio there. So I'm working with Pete Sokoloff who is our regular piano player with the Donnell Library band and with Peter Eckland, so we have this little trio. We are there on Wednesdays. So that still goes. And I feel I'm lucky. I'm in New York, I'm playing, I'm playing in New York twice a week. Hey, man.

MR: That's more than a lot of people can say.

JLC: It's more than a lot of people are doing. And it's getting worse and worse, there are more and more professional players who are willing now to play for their supper.

MR: Really.

JLC: Yeah. They'll come in —

MR: You mean like literally?

JLC: Literally play for their supper. If it's a chance to play what they want to play — no interference, no requests, and if they can come in there and do that it keeps the chops up, keeps them playing jazz, and a lot of guys more and more are doing this. And that's what you're seeing. But I feel so great, I'm still playing.

MR: Here's a statement I thought was interesting. You said it was "one of the curiosities of twentieth century America that art does not have to be very good to establish its creator as a person of distinction. It's only necessary that it be art."

JLC: Well that's true, where did I say that?

MR: I believe in the Ellington book.

JLC: The Ellington book? Yeah it's true. I mean it's certainly true and I'm not going to start naming names, I'm in enough trouble as it is. But you have novelists who nobody wants to read and yet they do because they feel they must or at least they read enough of it to be able to talk about the book. But they have a literary reputation. And once you get that literary reputation on one book then you go along and you get asked to contribute to seminars or people call to ask your opinion on things or on whatever you're doing. But do you have any readers? And I'm not saying that you're supposed to go out and whore for the greatest amount of readers you can get, no. But I do feel that you should be talking to somebody. You're not creating an artifact. You're not making a rocking chair or selling a quilt. You're not creating something. This is a system of communication. You're telling somebody something. You're talking to somebody. And if there's nobody out on the other end listening I don't quite see what the function of the thing is. Fine if you want

to do it, and sit home and do it and write because you like writing, that's fine. But you know, these reputations very often, literary or artistic reputations come and go pretty fast. So I think that that's true. And I do not like to call myself an author, I'm not an author, I'm a professional writer. That's what I am. And the term, to say you're a professional writer is almost pejorative because it means you might be concerned about story, it means you might be plotting, and so forth. It might be putting something in there that somebody might want to read. But that is what I am. I'm not an artist, I'm not an author. I'm a professional writer. And I happen to be a good one. But that's the attitude I take toward this. And once you start getting literary you're in trouble, you're in trouble.

MR: Well you're a good conversationalist too.

JLC: Well thank you.

MR: And I appreciate your illuminating some things about Hamilton, that was very interesting.

JLC: Well good.

MR: And I hope we see you up there at some point.

JLC: Well I don't know, I don't have any plans to get up — the problem is that the reunion weekend is always usually the prettiest weekend of the summer, you know, early in June, and I have a place up in the country here where I usually am during half the year, and I hate the idea of getting on the Thruway and driving for four hours to get on up there, but I'll get up there.

MR: Maybe on your sixtieth.

JLC: Well I'll certainly come up for my sixtieth God willing.

MR: Well thanks for your time today.

JLC: Well, Monk, thanks very much for having me. I appreciate it.